

The runner's strength week

Where those two sessions go, and the three things the routine doesn't train.

You've just done runner core. It's one piece, not the programme. This guide is the rest of it: how often, on which days, what goes untrained if this is all you do, and what to do when something hurts.

What you just trained

Running is a series of hops on one leg. At every landing the trunk has to absorb the impact, stop the free hip dropping, and resist the twist your arm swing generates. That is why the circuit is *anti*: anti-extension, anti-lateral-flexion, anti-rotation. And it finishes standing on one leg, because that is the position running actually happens in.

EXERCISE	WHAT IT TRAINS
Dead bug with isometric press	Anti-extension — keeping the lower back on the floor as the arm and leg travel away.
Side plank with knee to chest	Anti-lateral-flexion — the glute medius stopping the free hip from dropping.
High plank with forward reach	Anti-rotation — the trunk resisting the twist the arm swing generates.
Single-leg isometric bridge	Posterior chain — glute and hamstrings holding the hip up over one support.
Reverse lunge with rotation	Rotation and bipedal integration — the thorax turning while the pelvis stays still.
Single-leg deadlift	Single-leg support — balance, posterior chain and anti-rotation standing up, which is how you run.

The core doesn't create movement. It prevents it. So failure here isn't fatigue — it's the moment the pelvis starts to move. When that happens the set is over, reps left or not.

And what it doesn't

Three things a runner needs that this circuit doesn't touch. The first two are out on purpose, because another tool does them better. The third is out because of a decision that carries a cost, and I'd rather tell you.

1 The foot and calf spring

The Achilles tendon and the foot are the runner's real spring: they store and return energy on every stride. Nothing in this circuit loads them. If you're going to add one thing to your week, make it calf and foot work.

TOOL **Achilles Without Pain** — full routine, in the Members Area

2 Kneecap tracking under load

Runner's knee is almost never a knee problem. A weak glute medius lets the pelvis drop at every footfall, the knee collapses inward, and the patellar tendon and IT band pay for it. Here you train the pelvis unloaded — that's half the job.

TOOL **Knees Without Pain** — full routine, in the Members Area

3 The upper back

This gap is deliberate and I want you to know why. The routine swapped the prone superman for the single-leg deadlift, because the superman holds lumbar and hip extension at the same time — which is exactly the fault the first exercise in the circuit exists to prevent. The swap is worth it and it costs something: scapular endurance is trained nowhere in this circuit, and that is what keeps you tall and open-chested when the fatigue arrives.

If you're going to cover it, cover it with a prone W with your legs on the floor, or with rows. Not with a full superman: that puts back exactly what we took out.

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How often, and on which days

FREQUENCY	WHEN	NEVER
Twice a week	On easy running days, or after an easy run	Before a quality session

The question always comes up: does it work as a warm-up before intervals? No. It's fatiguing enough to dirty the technique of the session that follows, and there's already a specific activation routine for that — short, and it leaves no residue. This is support work, not a warm-up.

Two core sessions are not the programme. They're two pieces inside a running week that is still what decides your result.

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The full week

Four rules govern where strength goes in a running week. They aren't negotiable against each other: when they clash, the one above wins.

- 1 Leave at least 6 hours between the gym and the endurance session on the same day, where you can.
- 2 Never heavy legs the day before a quality session or the long run.
- 3 Stack the gym onto a day that's already hard, rather than spoiling an easy one.
- 4 Two gym sessions a week is the norm. Three or four only during a max-strength phase.

A five-run week with the rules applied

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Run	—	Quality	Easy	Quality	Easy	—	Long
Gym	—	After	—	After	—	—	—
Core	—	—	Yes	—	Yes	—	—

This is the week those rules produce, not the only one there is. If you have four days to run instead of five, the first thing to go is an easy day — not the gym. Dropping the gym is the most common mistake and it's on the next page.

At four, five or six runs a week plus the gym, the constraint that governs everything isn't time. It's fatigue.

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What strength buys you, and what it doesn't

Economy	Tissue resilience	Durability
The same pace costs you less oxygen.	Tendon, bone and muscle tolerate more impact before complaining.	You reach kilometre 32 with the form you had at 10.

What strength does **not** give you is more aerobic power. You'll read the opposite in plenty of places. Lifting doesn't raise your VO2max or your threshold — running does. Strength makes the engine you already have last longer and cost less.

How a 12-week block is ordered

PHASE	4 WEEKS	DOSE
1	Tissue tolerance	Twice a week · 6–10 reps · RIR 3
2	Max strength	3–5 sets × 3–5 reps · ≥85% · 3–5 min rest
3	Power	2–5 reps · 30–65% · maximal intent · stop when velocity drops

Each four-week phase is three loading weeks and one easy. If you're 50 or over: two loading and one easy, same as the endurance blocks.

No hypertrophy phase, on purpose

Almost every strength programme opens with four weeks of hypertrophy. This one doesn't. Added mass is a direct cost in watts per kilo and in running economy, and a runner is in a weight class — it's just one they set themselves. A real hypertrophy block exists as an off-season decision, taken deliberately and accepting the cost. Not as a starting point.

Maintenance

One session a week holds strength for weeks, as long as the load stays high and the volume drops. The classic race-week error is exactly the reverse: lighter weight, same number of sets. That maintains nothing and still costs you freshness.

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Four mistakes

Starting with hypertrophy

It's the default opening of almost every gym programme and it's the wrong one for you. You gain mass you then have to carry on every stride.

Heavy legs the day before quality

The quality session is what produces the week’s adaptation. Arriving at it on yesterday’s legs turns it into a mediocre session and into fatigue that bought nothing.

Maintaining by dropping the weight

In race week you drop the volume and keep the load. Doing it the other way round — same number of sets at half the weight — maintains no strength and still leaves you tired.

Dropping the gym when running volume climbs

The most common and the most expensive. Exactly when you’re running the most kilometres, the tissue absorbs the most impact and needs it most — and that is precisely when most people stop going, for lack of time.

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If something hurts

DURING	THE REAL TEST	IF IT’S WORSE
Discomfort of 1 to 3 out of 10 is acceptable. Above 4, or if it changes how you run, stop.	The next morning. Same or better than before you trained. Worse means the dose was too much.	Reduce range or load before you reduce frequency.

When this isn’t your routine, it’s an appointment

- Swelling, heat or redness in the area.
- The knee locks or gives way.
- Pain at night, at rest.
- Pain that started after an impact or a twist.
- A sudden snap with an inability to push off or rise onto your toes — that’s the same day, not next week.

I’m not a doctor and I don’t diagnose. When something lands on that list, what it needs is a professional who can actually look at you, not a generic routine. What I can do in the meantime is redistribute your load towards what doesn’t hurt, which is usually the difference between six weeks off and none.

You know where strength goes in your week. What's missing is the week itself.

These pieces work when they're sequenced — two quality sessions, the rest easy, and a progression that changes with the month of your build. Two ways to make that happen.

RECOMMENDED

All-Access Membership

US\$ 39.99/mo

The whole plan catalogue with the weeks already sequenced, plus the tools library: the Achilles and knee routines this guide points at, activation, mobility, recovery and the calculators.

- Running, cycling, triathlon and HYROX plans
- TrainingPeaks Premium included
- The full library of tools and guides
- No commitment — cancel whenever you want

Start with All-Access

IF YOU'D RATHER WE DECIDE TOGETHER

1:1 Coaching

US\$ 149/mo

A plan written for you and reviewed every week. Adjustments when life gets in the way, analysis of your sessions, and direct WhatsApp.

See how it works

Not sure which one fits? Write to me at coach@triaperformance.com and I'll tell you honestly which one applies — including if it's neither.